



**All smiles:** India staged a remarkable comeback against Argentina in the bronze-medal match, with coach P. R. Sreejesh calling the 4-2 victory after being two goals down one of the defining moments of the team's campaign. PICS: R. RAGU

campaign offered little beyond Prince Deep Singh's commendable goalkeeping and Arshdeep Singh's attacking flair. The coach, however, highlighted the bronze-medal match as the campaign's definitive moment, stating: "For me, being down 0-2 and then coming out and winning 4-2 in the last quarter is the best thing to have happened in the Junior World Cup. This was a huge pressure moment, but they faced it and won that challenge."

In the final, Germany secured its record-extending eighth title, triumphing over Spain 3-2 in a shootout after the match ended in a one-all stalemate. This marked Die Honamas' 13th podium finish in 14 editions.

Runner-up Spain was arguably the tournament's most visually pleasing team. Featuring skillful Catalan players, their silky stickwork and masterful midfield domination were reminiscent of the country's

all-conquering football team of the 2000s. Yet, their hopes of lifting a maiden world title were dashed in a thrilling shootout.

For the other hockey heavyweights, results were mixed. Belgium and the Netherlands both progressed to the quarterfinals but were unable to advance further. Meanwhile, France and New Zealand showcased steady progression. France, silver medallist in the previous edition, ultimately lost to Germany in a quarterfinal shootout.

Conversely, traditional powerhouse Australia had a poor outing. The Burras, who had won the Sultan of Johor Cup just prior to the event, looked vulnerable throughout and surprisingly failed to make it to the last eight.

#### Small steps on the grand stage

While the usual heavyweights made their presence felt in the knockout stages of the tournament, the

## Individual brilliance



### Best Player and FIH Rising Star of the Year

Casper van der Veen (NED)

### Top Scorer

Amirul Islam (BAN)

### Best Goalkeeper

Jasper Ditzer (GER)



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